Dos Corazones (Two Hearts)

By Richard Helleson

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: *Cheryl, in the throes of what appears to be postpartum depression, pours her heart out to Ana, another new mother who shares her room.*
ACTRESS 2: *She discovers that Ana speaks only Spanish, while Cheryl speaks only English.*
ACTRESS 1: *The two begin to communicate around language rather than exclusively through it.*
ACTRESS 2: *Ana, who has almost nothing, cannot understand why Cheryl-who appears to have almost everything-is so upset over becoming a mother. In particular, she seems most bitter over a gift from her husband: a necklace featuring a pendant of two hearts.*
ACTRESS 1: *Cheryl ultimately reveals the source-and depth-of her frustration and her fears, and learns from Ana the real meaning of . . .*
TOGETHER: *Dos Corazones by Richard Helleson*

In the dark, a woman humming a lullaby.
CHERYL lays there, asleep. - no makeup, exhausted eyes, hair which has long since been given up on - she is moving-in the throes of an increasingly intense dream.
ANA the other mother-stops rocking and returns her baby to his tray. She settles the baby, then turns her attention to CHERYL, who thrashes and ultimately cries out. The cry wakes her; she seems to be gasping for air, then is startled by ANA's presence. She exhales deeply, and sinks back into her pillow. A moment, as she appears to be holding back tears; then she turns to ANA, who simply watches.

CHERYL: I'm . . . I'm sorry. *(Sighs; shakes her head. Then she looks at ANA for a moment, who is still silent. Tired and somewhat mystified:)* I was . . . . swimming. In some sort of lake-I was way out there. And I got so tired of kicking . . . . my legs just got heavier and heavier, and I started to sink. I tried to fight it, but the harder I tried, the faster I went down. *(Slight pause)* And then I remembered . . . that the human body floats. Right If you just let it go, it floats. So I just . . . . let everything go. . . *(Pause)* Finally I decided that I would just drift back to the shore. Only there wasn't any shore. I looked around, and there wasn't any land at all. I thought, my God, nobody knows where I am. *(Tears up.)*

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Nobody knows. *(She deals with the tears, but there is a long pause. ANA continues to look at her; CHERYL responds with a half-smile.)*

ANA: Tu bebe esta bien? [Is your baby alright?] *(CHERYL and ANA look at each other. More deliberately)* Tu be be . . . [Your baby . . .] Esta bien? [Is she alright?]

CHERYL: *(Slight pause; nods a bit too much.)* Um . . . . Yes, she's mine . . . . Definitely mine . . . *(Smiles at ANA, who smiles back and nods. Indicates ANA'S baby.)* Yours?

ANA: Era un poco malo al principio-pero, es mejor ahora. [He was a little sick at first-but he's better now.]

CHERYL: *(Who hasn't understood a word, nods.)* Ah. *(pause)* Listen, um . . . *(Louder, as though that would help.)* I'm sorry I woke you up. I'm sorry, OK? *(More to herself)* I'm sorry about everything.

ANA: No hablo mucho Ingles- [I don't speak much English-]

CHERYL: Oh. Um, whatever . . .

ANA: -pero, algunas veces puedo entender. Sabes? [-but I can understand it sometimes. You know?] *(Gestures to her ear and her head.)* Ingles? [English?]

CHERYL: You . . . . hear it OK?

ANA: Mas O menos. Hablas Espanol? Un poco? [Sort of. You speak Spanish? A little?]

CHERYL: Um, yeah, un poco. El Espafiol de High School, but . . . *(Gestures as of language flying out of her head.)* Ffftt. Adios.

ANA: Otra lengua---es muy dificil. [Another language-it's very hard.] *(With great effort)* "Have a nice day."

CHERYL: Oh, the basics, huh? Um . . . "Dos margaritas, por favor."

ANA: Eso no estuviera mal . . . [That wouldn't be so bad . . .] "Big Mac with fries."

CHERYL: "Hola, Paco! Que tal?"

ANA: "I am having a baby."

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CHERYL: I am having a baby . . . *(Her smile fades.)*

ANA: Esta bien? [Is that O.K.?]

CHERYL: Sure. Perfecto. *(She sniffles again and reaches for Kleenex. ANA watches her for a moment.)*

ANA: Tu hija es muy bonita. [Your daughter is very beautiful.] *(Slight pause.)*

CHERYL: Oh. A girl. You have a little boy?

ANA: Si. [Yes.]

CHERYL: Your first? Primero?

ANA: *(Pause; nods slowly.)* Si. Nuestro primero. Til tambien? [Yes. Our first. You too?]

CHERYL: Mmm-hmm.

ANA: Como se llama? [What's her name?]

CHERYL: Um . . . Me Ilamo Cheryl.

ANA: Mucho gusto. Me llamo Ana. *(Slight pause)* (Y la bebe? [And your baby?]

CHERYL: *(as though she's just discovered the name herself)* Clare. It's Clare.

ANA: Clare. Bonito. [Clare. Pretty.]

CHERYL: How about yours? Como se llama?

ANA: Martin.

CHERYL: Marteen. That's a nice name . . . You must be happy to have a son. Very proud. *(Does "proud)]*

ANA: Si. [Yes.]

CHERYL: I think Nate wanted a boy. He didn't say anything, but . . . *(Begins absently fingering necklace she wears.)*

ANA: *(after a moment)* Tu collar es muy bonito. [Your necklace is very pretty.]

CHERYL: *(in her own thoughts)* Hmmm?

ANA: *(pointing)* Tu collar [Your necklace]

CHERYL: This?

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ANA: Si. Es tan bonito. Tu esposo te lo regalo? [Yes. It's so pretty. Your husband gave it to you?]

CHERYL: Yeah. It's from my esposo.

ANA: Dos corazones. [Two hearts.]

CHERYL: Dos . . .

ANA: Corazones. [Hearts.] *(Does the "heart" beating in her chest.)*

CHERYL: Hearts. Yes.

ANA: Ah . . . . que bueno. [Ah . . . . Nice.]

CHERYL: *(flatly)* Yes it is. *(Pause; begins to cry again.)* This is so stupid . . .

ANA: Que te pasa? [What's the matter?]

CHERYL: I just . . . . never mind.

ANA: *(after a pause)* Por que estas tan triste? [Why are you so sad?] *(Slight pause; CHERYL looks away.)* Tienes un bebe bonita - es un tiempo feliz - pero estas triste. Por que? [You have a beautiful baby--it's a happy time--but you're so sad. Why?]

CHERYL: Porque . . . . .It's all such a lie! Everything they tell you, everything they say is going to happen to you . . . . no es verdad, you know?

ANA: *(puzzled)* "No es verdad"? ["It's not true?"]

CHERYL: It's just -- this is the answer to the question, right? One of the questions. "How much weight have you gained?" Four hundred pounds - go away. "When are you due?" When, when, when. My God, there it is, just staring at you! . . . And then it's next week, and then it's this week, and then it's tomorrow . . . and then it's today . . . And then it's . . . yesterday, and then it's last week, and then . . . it happens. And it's such a lie.

ANA: No entiendo . . . [I don't understand . . .]

CHERYL: Here. Por ejemplo. *(Retrieves magazine from table, opens it to a page, shows ANA.)* Look at that. Tell me that's the truth. She just had a baby? Right. I

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mean, look at her! She's so . . . Sexy! She looks sexy! Like, "That was fun -- wanna start on another one?" Look at me! I lost thirty pounds in thirty seconds -- I feel like some kind of cow. *(ANA looks through the magazine some more.)* But that's the way you're supposed to be, right? Glowing - like the moon. *(Slight pause)* And nobody cares. Nobody. Except the nurses, and all they want to know is "How are your stitches? *(Shakes her head, sniffling.)* Everything was supposed to stop and wait-and it just kept going. Just kept right on going, like, So what? You thought you were special? *(Pause)* Yes. I thought I was. Kind of forgot to tell me about the triste, huh?

ANA: *(Nods quietly, almost to herself)* "En tristeza tendras hijos." ["In sorrow thou shalt bring forth children."]

CHERYL: Hmmm?

ANA: En el Biblio? Dios? Es . . . su primero castigado. En todas las madres-tristeza. "En tristeza tendras hijos." [In the Bible? God? It's . . . his first punishment. On all the mothers yet to come - sorrow. "In sorrow thou shalt bring forth children."]

CHERYL: I guess.

ANA: Pues . . . . Por que tuviste un bebe? [So . . . . why did you have a baby?] *(A pause; CHERYL shrugs.)* (Pero, si la quieres, no? Si la querias? [But you wanted her, didn't you? You must have wanted her . . .]

CHERYL: I don't know . . . I don't remember .

ANA: No entiendo . . . . [Tienes un bebe, y eres tan resentida! [I just don't understand . . . . You have a baby, and you're so . . . resentful!]

CHERYL: Look-

ANA: Por que? Tienes flores, y globos, y tienes una hija saludable! [Why? You have flowers, and balloons, and a healthy child!]

CHERYL: I DON'T REMEMBER, OK? I DON'T REMEMBER WHY. Just . . . *(quieter)* I

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don't remember. *(ANA turns away. CHERYL looks over at her, after a long pause:)* Part of me . . . por mi madre, maybe. *(Slight pause)* And . . . por mi esposo. To have . . . something more between us. Mas . . . . amor . . . *(fingering the necklace again)* And Nate was incredible. He really was-the whole pregnancy. We took those classes-clases? De childbirth? We'd do these pretend delivery room scenes, and he was totally in charge! "No monitors." "We're not gonna have drugs." "Get that LV. away from her!" I felt so safe. *(Slight pause)* And then this morning . . . He didn't say a word all the way to the hospital. We get here. . . . And you know what he does? He leaves. Hasta la vista. My labor takes off, and he goes to the bathroom! I couldn't believe it! *(A sniffle or two.)* Oh, and then? When he finally comes back? All this crap from the childbirth books finally kicks in. "Honey! I'm so proud of you! Thank you for working so hard!" *(Pause; quieter)* And then it's over. And I hold out my hand for him . . . . and I look up to see his face. What depth of love that I've never seen before will I see in his eyes? And you know what? I don't know. Because he's across the room looking through the video camera which he's holding about six inches over the baby. "Isn't this great? God, this is so great!" *(tearing up again)* He never even looked at me. *(Pause; playing with the necklace again)* And mi wonderful esposo . . . . went away for a long time, and then he came back-and he gave me this. *(Tears up again.)* He thought I was crying because I was happy.

ANA: *(referring to the necklace.)* No le gusta? [Don't you like it?]

CHERYL: I have no idea what it means! You want to know "por que"? Well so do I! Por que this?! It doesn't make any sense!

ANA: Dos corazones. [Two hearts.]

CHERYL: I know that, but . . . . Which two?! *(ANA shakes her head slightly, that she doesn't completely understand.)* Una familia? But that's three hearts, not two! Or, it's

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him and me? Like when you get married, it's two hearts with an arrow through them or something? Only it's not him and me anymore! That's over. *(Sniffles a bit.)* Or maybe it's something about what he loves-the baby and me. But he should be wearing that, not me! I don't know what it means! He's hanging it around my neck, and I don't know what it means!

ANA: Y tu? [And you?]

CHERYL: What about me.

ANA: Tuviste el bebe por tu mama . . . y por tu esposo . . . . No la tuviste por ti? [You had a child for your mother, and for your husband. What about for yourself?]

CHERYL: I told you, I don't remember! No recuerdo.

ANA: Pero . . . cuando la abrazas . . . No te acuerdas por que la tuviste? [But . . . . when you hold her . . . . You remember then, don't you? Why you wanted a child?] *(Cradles an imaginary baby.)* Cuando la abrazas . . . [When you hold her . . .]

CHERYL: When I hold her . . . ?

ANA: Si. Cuando estan aqui . . . . Te acuerdas por que la querias? [Yes. When they're right here . . . You remember why you wanted her?] *(ANA looks at CHERYL, who is silently crying.)* Cuando la abrazas? [When you hold her?] *(CHERYL shakes her head, trying not to sob.)* No? *(CHERYL shakes her head again; very gently:)* Por que? [Why not?]

CHERYL: Because I've never held her. *(ANA looks at her, not quite understanding.)* I've never . . . *(Imitates the action of holding the baby, then throws her hands up.)*

ANA: No has abrazado? [You've never held her?]

CHERYL: I can't . . . I just . . . . *(Lets herself cry.)* I wanted her so much-and then . . . . Everybody else had her. She was stressed, during the delivery-they took her down to the ICU for awhile . . . I never even got to touch her. I was so afraid . . . what if she was dead, or . . . ?

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ANA: No, no.

CHERYL: But when they brought her back later . . . I didn't want to touch her . . . I wanted them to take her away. Something in me . . . I wanted her to be dead. *(She continues to weep. ANA climbs into CHERYL's bed and puts her arms around her.)* How can I be her mother? I can't even hold her!

ANA: Ssshhhhh . . .

CHERYL: I want her so much . . .

ANA: Alli esta, [But she's there.]

CHERYL: Here. I want her here. *(Her womb.)* I want her inside, where she's safe, and . . . . she's mine . . . and I can hold her with my whole body, all the time-not out where they can take her away . . .

ANA: Esta bien . . . [It's alright . . .]

CHERYL: I want her on the inside, and Nate and me on the outside and nothing would change. But she's gone . . . And he's . . . . And I'm . . . . *(Looks at ANA for a moment; then, a tearful laugh.)* And you don't understand a thing I'm saying do you? God . . .

ANA: Yo no-? [I don't?]

CHERYL: Usted . . . no conoces . . . . Never mind.

ANA: Pero sf te entiendo. [But I do understand.]

CHERYL: No, you don't .

ANA: No, no, no---escuchas . . . [No, no, no---now listen . . . .] *(Backs off so that CHERYL can see her full face.)* *Nos entendemos aqui. [We understand each other here.]* *(Her heart.)* Es la unica cosa que importa. [That's the only thing that matters.] *(indicating the babies)* Porque tenemos nuestros nifios. Porque somos madres, ahora. Y creo . . . .. Los hombres-si?- [Because we have our children. Because we are mothers, now. And I think . . . . Men-yes?]

CHERYL: Men.

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ANA: Hablan de "corazones rompidos." Sabes? [They talk about "broken hearts." You know?] *(Makes a breaking motion with her hands.)* Corazones rompidos.

CHERYL: Broken hearts?

ANA: Todo el tiempo-los hombres: [All the time-men] *(Doing despairing male voice)* "[Ay! Ella se rompio mi corazon, ¡VOY a morir!" ["Oh! She broke my heart. I'm going to die!"] *(CHERYL smiles.)* Los corazones de los hombres nunca se rompen. Rompen sus cabezas--sus abrazos- [Men's hearts never really break. They break their heads-their arms-] *(A dismissive gesture. Slight pause.)* Pero, por nosotros . . . . en eso . . . [But for us . . . . in this . . .] *(Gestures around the room, the babies.)* El corazon de la mujer en verdad se rompe. [The heart of a woman truly breaks.] *(The breaking motion again, using her own heart.)* Rompe a la mitad. [Breaks in half.] *(using each fist as a heart)* Y eso es que sabe solamente las madres: como siente tener dos corazones en un cuerpo. Uno aqui- [That's what only mothers know: how it feels to have two hearts in one body. One here-] *(her chest}*-y uno aqui. [-and one here.] *(her womb)* Y un corazon siempre pulsa cerca la otra. Aunque cuando se vaya de su cuerpo. [And that heart always beats near your own heart. Even when it goes out of you.] *(Indicates the second heart leaving her body.)* Aunque cuando se pierda . . . . Aunque si se morio su nifio, tienes dos corazones. Siempre. [Even when you lose it. Even if your child dies, you have two hearts. Always.]

CHERYL: *(Slight pause; getting sense of the last part.)* Wait . . . ? mono . . . .

ANA: *(touching the necklace)* Creo que tu esposo te quiere mucho--- [I think that your husband must love you very much-] -para te entiende tan bien. [-to understand you so well.] *(She slowly returns to her own bed.)*

CHERYL: Morio . . . dies? A child-dies? *(ANA says nothing.)* What-que nifio? *(ANA says nothing.)* Martin . . . . Es your first-your primero . . .

ANA: *(looking at her baby, and nodding)* Si. El primero. [Yes. The first.]

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CHERYL: How many . . . . Sus nifios. How many have . . . morio. *(Pause; ANA holds up three fingers. A long moment, then:)*

ANA: Dos . . . [Two . . .] *(Gestures as of something flushing out of her body.)* Eso ya paso. Ellos no viviera-nunca seran bebes. [It happens. They wouldn't have lived-they were never really babies anyway.] *(Slight pause)* La tercera . . . Su cuerpo nacio-s-pero su espiritu [The third one. Her body was born-but her soul] *(Indicates a soul flying up=-gone.)* Ya se fue. *[Was already gone.}* *(Smiles slightly.)* Era muy pequefia, pero . . . . era tan linda. [She was very small, but . . . . she was so pretty.] *(Again, cradles an imaginary baby.)* La abraze por tanto tiempo como pude. Pretend! que ella estaba durmiendo. [I held her as long as they'd let me. I pretended that she was just sleeping . . .] *(She begins to hum the lullaby-first without words, then adding the words quietly. After a moment, ANA sees CHERYL staring at her, and stops singing abruptly.)* Perd6name---es tarde. [I'm sorry-it's late.]

CHERYL: No . . . It's a beautiful song. *(Looks down, holding the necklace in the palm of her hand.)*

ANA: No te preocupe que significa el collar. [Don't worry about what it means.] *(indicating the baby.)* Abrazala. Mientes puedes. [Hold her. While you can.*]* *(A pause. ANA checks on her own baby; as she does, CHERYL slowly and painfully moves to the edge of her bed. ANA begins humming the tune again. CHERYL walks hesitantly over to her baby, then stands and looks down at her. The room light, and then the moonlight, fade out.)*

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Richard Helleson
Book: The Best 10-Minutes Plays: 2012
ISBN: 978-1575257938
Publisher: Smith and Kraus
Date (Month/Year): June 2013